



Critical Studies and Reviews

F. David Martin. *Sculpture and Enlivened Space: Aesthetics and History*. Lexington: The University Press of Kentucky, 1981. 276 pages. \$24.00. Stephen David Ross. *A Theory of Art: Inexhaustibility by Contrast*. Albany: State University of New York Press, 1982. 246 pages. Cloth, \$33.50; Paper, \$10.95. (Reviewed by William Dean, Gustavus Adolphus College.)

One consequence of the recent growth of process and pragmatic modes of thought is a new importance for aesthetics. For these modes of thought emphasize the ways in which we live in time, rather than beyond time. For them the present must be evaluated at some moment, and never from a standpoint beyond all moments. And the key to this temporal evaluation is aesthetics.

So these modes of thought have consequences, but sometimes the full appreciation of a consequence is delayed. Process thought and pragmatism increasingly recognize that, if there is no eternal truth, then our lot is to assess events in terms of how they contribute to present and future aesthetic value. I find this awareness in, for example, John Cobb's and David Griffin's *Process Theology: An Introductory Exposition* and in Richard Rorty's *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature*. Such persons are working with modes of thought which were introduced in the first decades of this century, and the consequences they draw can contribute to the guidance of the last two decades of this century.

If aesthetics is to be converted from luxury to leadership, books such as Martin's *Sculpture and Enlivened Space* and Ross's *A Theory of Art* warrant serious attention.

Both books develop aesthetic theories in a process context, but they do this in entirely different ways. F. David Martin's hypothesis about sculpture is as strange as it is because it accepts a bodily form of perception, one which is openly dependent upon Whitehead's sense of causal efficacy. Stephen David Ross's aesthetic theory is as abstract as it is because it accepts the sufficiency of theory, in this case a theory which is openly dependent upon Whitehead's theory of contrast.

Martin and Ross take opposite positions on the question of where aesthetic deliberation is properly to be located. Is the aesthetician to sit with the artist and take the pulse of the one undergoing aesthetic experience, in order to shout up the diagnosis from time to time? Or is the aesthetician one who works with pencils and thinkers to generate a theory which might give order to the confusion below? Martin in *Sculpture and Enlivened Space* grinds his points through continuous contrast with art. Ross in *A Theory of Art* approaches the arts with his theory already sharpened and his metaphysical bag over his shoulder,

so that as he speculatively wanders he occasionally stabs a scrap of art on the point of his theory and—almost without looking—lets it drop into his bag. Ross sets one to thinking of grand schemes, just as Martin calls up the greater empiricism of a William James, fumbling to make sense of the buzzing, blooming confusion, or of a Whitehead in *Modes of Thought*, trying to explain what you feel when you first enter a room (MT 109).

Martin quite seriously argues that sculpture is not about the piece of sculpture itself, but about the “enlivened space” surrounding the sculpture—what the sculpture does to that space and what that space in turn means. This rather spooky hypothesis makes sense only if Martin’s empiricism—or, as he would prefer, his phenomenology—is understood. The epistemology must be understood, for otherwise there is no answer to the obvious criticism: How can sculpture be about space when the space cannot be seen? On this unstated question turns not only Martin’s theory of knowledge, but his practical way into that theory—his own effort to say why the autonomy of sculpture has never been properly recognized.

We have neglected the autonomy of sculpture because we have neglected, Martin argues, what Whitehead calls “causal efficacy,” what Merleau-Ponty calls “primordial perception.” We have neglected a radical empiricism, an empiricism which perceives not only through the five senses, but through a palpable, haptic, kinaesthetic, tactile, or, in a word, a bodily sensibility. Perceiving bodily, we can sense a “withness,” not with the sculptured object itself, but with the space which the sculpture enlivens. Sculpture is about the spatial relations between the sculptured thing and the observer. Only when one gets this straight does one realize why sculpture, unlike painting, is so affected by its location, by the people around it, by how the observer moves around it. Only then does one realize that an Alberto Giacometti sculpture is not about, say, certain stick figures, but about the dead urban space which surrounds them, or that a Henry Moore sculpture is not about smooth-surfaced humanoids, but about the earth into which they draw one.

We have given aesthetics over, Martin suggests, too completely to what Whitehead would call “presentational immediacy,” that abstracting process which saves for consciousness a few clear and distinct images out of the more fundamental, vague totality felt by the body. The focusing eye is the organ par excellence of presentational immediacy. And the eye prefers, not the invisible space surrounding sculpture, but the distant, objective, two-dimensional, and clearly visible painting.

Martin, true to his epistemology, repeatedly invokes that experience most primitive for himself—his own experience. So his otherwise gauche comments, such as, “As I walked into a room in the Philadelphia Museum of Art . . .,” become apt. And yet his book is not preciously subjective; it contains ninety-two good photographs of the sculptures Martin discusses, inviting the reader to compare his or her experience to Martin’s. True also to his empiricism is Martin’s will-

ingness to comment on the valuational meanings of what is bodily experienced.

Martin's aesthetic study of sculpture is also a case study in how radical empiricism and phenomenology as methods of inquiry can begin to be practically utilized in ordinary situations.

I would fault Martin for claiming too little, in two ways. First, in his effort to establish the autonomy of sculpture, Martin has limited the aesthetics of space and even of bodily perception to the observation of sculpture (and to architecture), whereas I think it could be found in painting and the other arts as well. Cannot the depth of space be felt differently after seeing a Rothko painting or the ominousness of space be felt differently after hearing Bartok? Second, I would like to have seen Martin give his epistemological comments broader implication by tying them more completely to Whitehead's or to Merleau-Ponty's metaphysics; Martin successfully undertook this more philosophical analysis in his earlier *Art and the Religious Experience*. But then, this may be to push Martin too far into theory and too far away from the directness of contact he so well preserves in the book here reviewed.

Or, this might push him to the theoretical extreme taken by Stephen David Ross. Ross initially sets forth a perfectly sensible aesthetic hypothesis, which he calls the "ordinal theory," and which is in close touch with the spirit of American process and pragmatic thought and with the recent deconstructionist thought emanating from France, particularly from Jacques Derrida. The ensuing two hundred pages of exposition, however, drift through clouds of abstraction; they never set down for a sustained discussion of any particular piece of art, nor even for a serious discussion of the connection between ordinal theory and other aesthetic or art-critical theories. One has little idea how the hypothesis might be used in one's actual negotiations with aesthetic objects.

There are two major elements in Ross's ordinal theory. First, aesthetic value is found in intensity of contrast. Ross takes this notion from Whitehead's conclusion that aesthetic value lies in the proper unification of diverse elements into a single experience. However, Ross prefers to locate the contrast in the relation between objects, rather than in the relation between the elements within a person's subjective experience (p. 5). (This, itself, is an interesting but undeveloped rejoinder to Whitehead.)

Second, Ross claims that aesthetic contrasts are "inexhaustible" because they are always newly realized as time passes. An art piece creates contrasts as it relates to its environment, but as the environment changes, so the contrasts change. In other words, as the order of the environment changes, so the order of contrasts between the art and its environment changes—hence, the "ordinal theory" of aesthetics (pp. 10–11).

The irony of Ross's book is that it denies that orders exist apart; it insists that orders arise from relations with other orders. Yet as a book, it attempts, except for the first two chapters, to live alone, breathing its

own air over and over again.

Nevertheless, in principle, for Ross as for Martin, aesthetic value is found in the relations between the art piece and the things external to the art piece. For Ross the relations are between the art and its environment; for Martin the relations are between the art and the observer. But for both Ross and Martin, being in the deepest sense is in time. In a deconstructionist vein Ross says, "There is no general sense of being different from the being of every order" (p. 59). This leads, finally, not to an eternal beauty, but to temporal and passing beauties. And it is these, both Martin and Ross suggest, which engender temporal and passing values for persons who are also temporal and passing.